

THE MASTER OF ILLUSION

As frontman for the Indian Cricket League, Kapil Dev uses the power of his persona to play a game he has long perfected



ICONIC: Dev at the ICL signing spree

Photographs by BHASKAR PAUL

■ By Sharda Ugra

Maybe no one noticed. The inaugural training camp of the Indian Cricket League (ICL) is being held at a Chennai complex called 'Mayajaal'. The name, roughly translated, means the 'web of illusion'. Not quite the message to convey when claiming to shake the roots of Indian cricket.

Or perhaps the joke is on us. ICL have found, as their voice and face, the most deft master illusionist of them all—the iconic Kapil Dev. In recent weeks, Dev, a former India captain and coach, has carpet bombed a dotting public with overheated words backed most compellingly, by the powerful memory of his deeds.

Dressed in blood red at the signing

THE BCCI | INTERNAL RUMBLINGS

The Case of the Missing Crores

To the BCCI, the ICL is not an inconvenient truth, but a convenient distraction. There is a rumbling of discontent after a deal went bust and the small sum of Rs 240 crore (just under half of India's current sports budget of Rs 495 crore), quite simply, seemed to have dematerialised.

After the failing to win the BCCI's telecast rights, Zee Sports were awarded rights to India's 'off-shore' cricket in April 2006. Zee were awarded rights to matches in non-

of 44 domestic cricketers to ICL, Dev, 48, swore to defend them till his dying day, and threw in a promised hunger strike too. In a newspaper, a few days later, he felled Sunil Gavaskar, Dilip Vengsarkar, Sachin Tendulkar and Rahul Dravid with one lusty swipe, narrowly missing out on a five-fer.

Then in a blink, he was on TV, holding forth on existential ethics, being called "Paaji" by an adoring Navjot Singh Sidhu and Ajay Jadeja. No matter what ICL is paying Dev—the figure of Rs 12 crore is whispered—they have already got their money's worth. Dev's